CHILDREN'S STORIES

OVERVIEW

Applying leadership and 21st century skills, participants create an illustrated children's story of high artistic, instructional, and social value. The narrative may be written in prose or poetry and take the form of a fable, adventure story, or other structure. The physical story book should be of high quality, designed to meet the year's given theme, which will be posted on the TSA website under *Themes & Problems*.

ELIGIBILITY

Three (3) teams or three (3) individuals per state may participate.

TIME LIMITS

SEMIFINAL ROUND

A. Ten (10) minutes per team are allotted for the teams to complete a presentation on the illustration technique, design process, writing and editing process, and book construction.

B. Five (5) minutes are allotted for the interview.

ATTIRE

TSA competition attire is required for this event.

PROCEDURE

PRE-CONFERENCE

A. Participants review the TSA Honor Statement for Competitive Events found in the General Rules.

B. Participants review the Use of Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI) found in the General Rules.

C. Partcipants review the annual design challenge found on the TSA website under *Themes & Problems*.

D. Participants concentrate their efforts researching children's books and literature, particularly the creation of storybooks similar to the annual design challenge (e.g., pop-ups, interactive books, etc.).

E. Participants develop a high-quality children's storybook with illustrations.

F. Participants record their design process in a documentation portfolio.

G. Participants "field test" their storybook and document outcomes and findings.

PRELIMINARY ROUND

A. No more than two (2) team representatives report to the time and place stated in the conference program to submit:

   1. Storybook
   2. Documentation portfolio

B. Entries are reviewed by judges with neither students nor advisors present.

   1. Judges score the Storybook criteria to determine the top twenty-four (24) preliminary contestants, which will not be posted.
   2. Judges score the Documentation Portfolio criteria of those top twenty-four contestants to determine the top twelve (12) semifinalist teams.

C. A list of twelve (12) semifinalist teams (in random order) is posted.

SEMIFINAL ROUND

A. Participants report at the time and place stated in the conference program to sign up for a presentation and interview time.

B. Participants report at the assigned time and place for the presentation and interview.

C. Presentation and interview is limited to up to three (3) members. All members that are present will participate in the presentation and interview process, which lasts up to ten (10) minutes for the presentation and up to five (5) minutes for the interview.

D. No more than two (2) team members pick up the team's entry from the display area at the time and place stated in the conference program.

E. The top ten (10) finalists are announced during the conference award ceremony.

REGULATIONS AND REQUIREMENTS

Students will work to develop their leadership and 21st century skills in the process of preparing for and participating in this TSA competitive event. The development and application of those skills must be evi-dent in their submission, demonstration, and/or communication pertaining to the entry.

PRE-CONFERENCE/PRELIMINARY ROUND

A. Storybook:

1. Participants design and create an entirely original storybook, complete with narrative and illustrations to meet the annual design challenge.
2. Physical storybook should be of high quality, designed to meet the age group for which it is intended. For the purposes of this event, children are defined as those twelve (12) years or younger.
3. Together with the storybook, the narrative and accompanying illustrations should result in an experience that delights, enlightens, and contributes to the wholesome development of a child.
4. Storybook and narrative with accompanying illustrations should take no more than ten (10) minutes to read and view.
5. Maximum reading time is twelve (12) minutes, and no minimum.
6. Physical storybook must not exceed 12" x 12" when closed.
7. There is no limit on the number of inside pages (may be one or two-sided).
8. Team must determine which format best presents the team's narrative and illustrations.
9. There must be a minimum of seven (7) illustrations that enhance the story and deepen the child's understanding and enjoyment of the reading experience.
    a. An illustration on the book's cover may count as one (1) of the required seven (7) illustrations.
    b. Team may use the cover illustration within the story as well.
    c. All illustrations MUST be original, freehand, and/or computer-generated drawings made by the team member(s).
    d. All computer-generated work MUST be developed from primitive lines and shapes and be the sole work of the team members.
    e. Physical or computer templates, previously existing drawings, characters, backgrounds, etc., are NOT PERMITTED.
10. Storybook may include the name of the author(s) and illustrator(s) on the cover and is exempt from the general rule that no identifying information may be used.
11. Copyrighted material is NOT PERMITTED.
12. All components, including the physical binding, must be the original work of the team members. No professional binding is allowed.
13. If narrative or illustrations appear in the story and they are not authored by one of the team members, the team is disqualified.
14. Photographic verification of the book construction process must be included in the portfolio.
15. Story must be no more than fifteen hundred (1500) words.
    a. There is a five (5)-point deduction for every hundred (100) words over the fifteen hundred (1500) word limit.
    b. Stories containing two thousand (2000) or more words is disqualified.
    c. There is no minimum number of words required.
    d. Word count (number of words comprising the story's narrative) must be listed on the inside of the front cover of the book.
16. Publishing rights remain with the authors and illustrators.

B. Documentation Portfolio:
   1. Documentation materials (comprising "a portfolio") are required and must be secured in a clear front report cover with the following single-sided, 8½" x 11" pages, in this order:
      a. Title page with the title of the story, the event title, the conference city and state, the year, and the team/individual chapter ID number; one (1) page
      b. Table of contents; pages as needed
      c. Purpose of story; one (1) page
         i. Story's intent
         ii. Summary of storyline and theme
         iii. Intended audience (age, gender, demographics, and special disabilities, if any)
      d. Photographic verification of book construction and binding; pages as needed
      e. Field Test Summary. A "field test" is a reading of the storybook to a group of children in the intended target age range; maximum of two (2) pages
         i. A minimum of two (2) field tests must be conducted.
         ii. Participants must document each field test with a summary paragraph that details the outcome findings.
         iii. Each summary paragraph must include the date, time, and location of the field test.
         iv. Each "field test" must be signed off by the chapter advisor.
      f. Research summary: A written summary of the research, writing strategies, problems encountered, and solutions developed in the writing and illustrating of the story; one (1) page.
      g. Project summary: A written summary of the research into the creation of storybooks similar to the annual design challenge (e.g. paper folding, interactive features in books). Summary must include the process and challenges the team encountered and the solutions developed in overcoming them; one (1) page.
      h. A list of tools, software (if any), and techniques used in the creation of the physical storybook and illustrations, not to exceed one (1) page.
      i. References/research sources; one (1) page.
      j. Photo/Film/Video Consent and Release Forms – recognizable individuals pictured in the images (minors require parental consent) must give their written consent before the images can be used in this event (see 2027 & 2028 Forms Appendix); pages as needed
      k. Resources and AI Reflection (see 2027 & 2028 Forms Appendix); maximum of four (4) pages

SEMIFINAL ROUND

A. A team representative of each semifinalist team reports at the time and location in the conference program to receive a presentation/interview time.
B. A maximum of three (3) team members will be given up to ten (10) minutes to present their book and discuss their design process with the judges and then up to five (5) minutes for an interview.
C. All team members must be prepared to answer interview questions and discuss illustrations included in the story.

EVALUATION

PRELIMINARY ROUND

Tier 1

A. Physical storybook

Tier 2

B. Documentation portfolio

SEMIFINAL ROUND

A. Presentation

B. Interview

Refer to the official rating form for more information.

GENERATIVE ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI) is permitted for this event. Refer to the Use of Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI) for Competitive Events found in the General Rules and Regulations.

STEM INTEGRATION

Depending upon the subject written about, this event may align with one or more STEM (Science, Technology, Engineering, and Mathematics) educational standards. Please refer to the STEM Integration section of this guide for more information.

LEADERSHIP AND 21ST CENTURY SKILLS

This event provides opportunity for students to build and develop leadership and 21st century skills including but not limited to – Communication, Collaboration/Social Skills, Initiative, Problem Solving/Risk Taking, Critical Thinking, Perseverance/Grit, Creativity, Relationship Building/Teamwork, Dependability/Integrity, and Flexibility/Adaptability

CAREERS RELATED TO THIS EVENT

This competition has connections to one (1) or more of the careers below:

- Writer
- Illustrator
- Educator
- Editor
- Publisher
- Graphic artist

Participant/Team ID# _____

CHILDREN'S STORIES

2027 & 2028 OFFICIAL RATING FORM

HIGH SCHOOL

Judges: Using minimal (1-4 points), adequate (5-8 points), or exemplary (9-10 points) performance levels as a guideline in the rating form, record the scores earned for the event criteria in the column spaces to the right. The X1 or X2 notation in the criteria column is a multiplier factor for determining the points earned. (Example: an "adequate" score of 7 for an X1 criterion = 7 points; an "adequate" score of 7 for an X2 criterion = 14 points.) A score of zero (0) is acceptable if the minimal performance for any criterion is not met.

Go/No Go Specifications

- Before judging the entry, ensure that the items below are present; indicate presence with a check mark in the box.
- If an item is missing, leave the box next to the item blank and place a check mark in the box labeled ENTRY NOT EVALUATED.
- If a check mark is placed in the ENTRY NOT EVALUATED box, the entry is not to be judged.

☐ TIER 1 – Storybook is present
☐ TIER 2 – Documentation portfolio is present
☐ ENTRY NOT EVALUATED

TIER 1 – STORYBOOK (130 points)				
CRITERIA	Minimal performance	Adequate performance	Exemplary performance	Record scores in the column spaces below.
	1-4 points	5-8 points	9-10 points	
Story Narrative (X3)	Narrative is poorly written; there is little apparent purpose; it is lacking a coherent theme and storyline.	Narrative's purpose is somewhat clear, with a focused theme and storyline; pacing and the development of characters and events is somehwhat paced, but has room for improvement.	Narrative is extremely well written with a clear purpose; storyline is fast paced and exciting; details are rich and enchanting.	
Illustrations (X3)	Artisanship of the illustrations reflects little technical skill; illustrations add little value to the story's narrative, storyline, and/or theme.	Artisanship of most illustrations reflects some technical skill; illustrations add some value to the story's narrative, storyline, and theme.	Artisanship of illustrations is excellent, reflecting sophisticated technical skills; illustrations enhance the story's narrative, storyline, and theme, and they are of high esthetic quality.	
Book Binding, Construction and Concept (X3)	Book construction demonstrates little or no creativity or innovation; minimal consideration is given to basic design principles and book construction; book is poorly constructed or is not bound.	Construction of the book is of good quality and demonstrates some degree of creativity and innovation; demonstrates an understanding of basic design principles; adequate choice of materials was used in its construction; book is bound with adequate materials.	Book is designed with attention to detail; construction is of high quality and demonstrates a thorough understanding of design principles; an excellent choice of materials was used in the construction of the book; book was bound with appropriate materials and shows understanding of proper techniques.	
Impact (X3)	Story (narrative, with the illustrations) is lacking in purpose and coherence; it is not very interesting; it lacks artistic, and/or instructional, and/or social value.	Story (narrative, with the illustrations) reflects a purpose and incorporates artistic, instructional, and social value; it is somewhat compelling and entertaining.	Story (narrative, with the illustrations) is beautifully told; it is compelling, entertaining, purposeful, and it reflects high artistic, instructional, and social value.	
Theme (X1)	Annual theme is not addressed.	Annual theme is somewhat addressed but doesn't contribute to the effectiveness of the overall design.	Annual theme is addressed and contributes to the effectiveness of the overall design.	
			TIER 1 – STORYBOOK SUBTOTAL (130 points)	

Story length violation: For stories exceeding 1,500 words, a deduction of 5 points will be incurred for every 100 words more than 1,500 up to 2,000. Stories of 2000 words or greater will be disqualified. Example: 1600 – 1699 words - 5 points; 1700 – 1799 words - 10 points; 1800 – 1899 words - 15 points; 1900 – 1999 words - 20 points; 2000 words and above, disqualified.	
Rules violations (a deduction of 20% of the total possible points for the above sections) must be initialed by the judge, coordinator, and manager of the event. Record the deduction in the space to the right. Indicate the rule violated: _____	
TIER 1 – SUBTOTAL (130 points)	

TIER 2 – DOCUMENTATION PORTFOLIO (100 points)				Record scores in the column spaces below.
CRITERIA	Minimal performance	Adequate performance	Exemplary performance	
	1-4 points	5-8 points	9-10 points	
Portfolio Components (X1)	Portfolio is unorganized and/or is missing three (3) or more components.	Portfolio is missing one (1) or two (2) components and/or is loosely organized.	Portfolio has all required components and is well organized.	
Purpose of Story (X1)	Story's intent, storyline, and theme are poorly explained and/or the intended audience is not identified.	Story's intent, storyline, theme, and intended audience are adequately explained.	Story's intent, storyline, theme, and intended audience are complete and well explained.	
Photographic Verification (X1)	Photographic verification is very unorganized or is missing.	Photographic verification is somewhat disorganized and is missing a few components; process is somewhat outlined.	Photographic verification has all components and is well organized; process is clearly outlined.	
Field Test (X1)	Field test report is poorly organized and is missing one (1) or more field tests; missing advisor's signature.	Field test report is organized but is missing critical information about the field tests.	Field test report is organized and contains the date, time and location of field tests; contains advisor's signature.	
Research Summary (X2)	Summary of the research, design, and writing process is poorly done and/or is incomplete.	Summary of the research, design, and writing process is somewhat clear and generally complete.	Summary of the research, design, and writing process is very well written, detailed, clear, and complete.	
Project Summary (X1)	Summary of the project is poorly written and missing the process and challenges faced.	Summary is somewhat clear and is missing the process or the challenges faced.	Summary is clear and concise and contains a detailed summary of the project process and challenges faced.	
List of Tools/ Software (X1)	List is missing several components and/or it is unorganized.	Most tools and software used are included; list is generally organized and complete.	All tools and software is included; list is organized and complete.	
References and Resources (X1)	There are few references listed and/or the references listed show little relevance to the project's goal or are not credible.	There are a sufficient number of references listed and the research base has some credible references.	Many quality references are listed, reflecting research in writing and illustrating for children, and in child development.	
Resources and AI Reflection (X1)	Form is incomplete or vague and does not clearly explain whether or how AI was used, showing little connection to the submission or understanding of effectiveness and ethics.	Form is complete and clearly explains AI use or the lack thereof with connections to the submission or theme/topic (when applicable), addressing effectiveness and ethical considerations with adequate analysis.	Form is complete, concise, and specific, critically evaluating how AI or non-AI tools shaped decisions and outcomes, with strong alignment to the submission or theme/topic (when applicable) and ethical reasoning.	

TIER 2 – DOCUMENTATION PORTFOLIO SUBTOTAL (100 points)	
Rules violations (a deduction of 20% of the total possible points for the above sections) must be initialed by the judge, coordinator, and manager of the event. Record the deduction in the space to the right. Indicate the rule violated: _____	
PRELIMINARY SUBTOTAL (230 points)	

SEMIFINAL PRESENTATION AND INTERVIEW (40 points)

CRITERIA	Minimal performance	Adequate performance	Exemplary performance	Record scores in the column spaces below.
	1-4 points	5-8 points	9-10 points	
Knowledge (X3)	Participants seem to have little understanding of the concepts in their project; answers to questions may be vague.	Participants exhibit a general understanding of the concepts in their project.	Participants show clear evidence of a thorough understanding of their project.	
Articulation (X1)	Communication of the design process is unclear, unorganized, and or illogical; leadership and/or 21st century skills are not evident.	Communication of the design process is somewhat logical and clear; leadership and/or 21st century skills are somewhat evident.	Communication of the design process is clear, concise, and logical; leadership and/or 21st century skills are clearly evident.	

SEMIFINAL PRESENTATION AND INTERVIEW SUBTOTAL (40 points)	
Rules violations (a deduction of 20% of the total possible points for the above sections) must be initialed by the judge, coordinator, and manager of the event. Record the deduction in the space to the right. Indicate the rule violated: _____	
SEMIFINAL SUBTOTAL (40 points)	
To arrive at the TOTAL score, add any subtotals and subtract rules violation points, as necessary. **TOTAL** (270 points)	

Comments:

I certify these results to be true and accurate to the best of my knowledge.

JUDGE

Printed name: _____ Signature: _____

CHILDREN'S STORIES
EVENT COORDINATOR INSTRUCTIONS

PERSONNEL

A. Event coordinator

B. Judges:

   1. Preliminary round, two (2) or more
   2. Semifinal round, two (2) or more

C. Assistants for check-in, two (2)

MATERIALS

A. Coordinator's packet, containing:

   1. Event guidelines, one (1) copy for the coordinator and for each judge
   2. TSA Event Coordinator Report
   3. Stick-on labels for identifying entries

B. Stopwatch

C. Storage containers or display tables for entries (tables minimum depth 18")

D. Table and chairs for judges and two (2) semifinalist team representatives

E. Interview questions

RESPONSIBILITIES

AT THE CONFERENCE

A. Attend the mandatory coordinator's meeting at the designated time and location.

B. Report to the CRC room and check the contents of the coordinator's packet.

C. Review the event guidelines and check to see that enough personnel have been scheduled.

D. Inspect the area(s) in which the event is to be held for appropriate set-up, including room size, tables, chairs, etc. Notify the event manager of any potential problems.

E. At least one (1) hour before the event is scheduled to begin, meet with the judges to review time limits, procedures, regulations, evaluation, and all other details related to the event. If questions arise that cannot be answered, speak to the event manager before the event begins.

F. Ensure the judges have access to the online judging system.

EVENT CHECK-IN

A. Check in the entries at the time stated in the conference program.

B. Participants check in:

   1. Storybook
   2. A hard copy of the portfolio

C. Each entry must include the participant's identification number on the inside cover of the entry.

D. Late entries are considered on a case-by-case basis and only when the lateness is caused by events beyond the participant's control.

E. In order to compete, participants must be on the entry list or must have approval of the CRC.

F. Ensure the judges have access to the online judging system.

G. If check-in is on the first day of the conference, requirements for attire do NOT apply during check-in.

H. Position the entries for evaluation and viewing.

I. Secure the entries in the designated area

PRELIMINARY ROUND

A. Judges independently assess the entries using the following procedure:

   1. Judges score the Storybook criteria to determine the top twenty-four (24) preliminary contestants, which will not be posted.
   2. Judges score the Documentation Portfolio criteria of those top twenty-four (24) contestants to determine the top twelve (12) semifinalist teams.

B. Decisions about rules violations must be discussed and verified with the judges, event coordinator, and CRC manager to determine either:

   1. To deduct twenty percent (20%) of the total possible points in this round or
   2. To disqualify the entry

   The event coordinator, judges, and CRC manager must initial either of these actions on the rating form.

C. Create semifinalist sign-up sheet for the semifinal interviews.

SEMIFINAL ROUND

A. Semifinalists report at the time and place stated in the conference program to sign-up for the presentation and interview.

B. Semifinalists report at the assigned time and place for the presentation and interview.

C. Manage the semifinalist presentation and interviews.

D. Discuss rule violations (e.g. 20% deduction, disqualification) and have all relevant parties initial the rating form.

E. If necessary, manage security and the removal of materials from the event area.